Despite the Congress's support, when elections to the 140-member influential Shiromani Gurudwara Parbhandhak Committee (SGPC) were held in 1979, only four persons supported by Bhindranwale were elected. None of the candidates supported by the Dal Khalsa were elected.

'No Sign of Militancy'

That Op-1 could not bring about any significant change on the ground till the end of 1979 is evident from the description of Punjab at the time by a highly regarded Indian Civil Service officer, B.G. Deshmukh, who retired as cabinet secretary. He wrote about it in his book, *From Poona to the Prime Minister's Office: A Cabinet Secretary Looks Back.*

Deshmukh was posted as additional secretary in the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) from May 1978 to early 1981, with police and law and order as his major charge. Sometime in the middle of 1979, Deshmukh travelled by road to Amritsar and met SGPC officials, visitors to the Golden Temple complex, farmers and villagers.

At Amritsar he found that the main concern of a senior official of the SGPC and some of his colleagues was that Punjab's prosperity had spoilt Sikh youth, who spent their time enjoying themselves and did not want to visit gurudwaras. Deshmukh found that the visitors to the Golden Temple complex, especially those from rural areas, showed 'no sign at all of any militancy' and had no interest in Bhindranwale's militant approach, even though 'he was moving vigorously and widely in the region'. [8]

Deshmukh's planned meeting with Bhindranwale, however, did not materialize. On his way to and from Amritsar, he met residents of small towns and roadside villages, and also stopped and spoke with people working in the fields, mainly Sikhs. 'They were a happy lot and offered genuine hospitality and the whole region seemed a haven of prosperity and peace,' was his observation. Deshmukh also visited Ludhiana, the industrial and trading hub of Punjab. There he met a number of prosperous traders and manufacturers (mostly Hindus), and again found no sign of any anxiety or violence in that city. [9]